

PUNJAB & MUGHLAI ORIGIN

# Naan

Soft, Pillowy Leavened Flatbread

The Classic North Indian Tandoor Bread

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

# LICENSE & COPYRIGHT NOTICE

## Naan

Sold via: Gumroad
Publisher: DhanioDigital  (dhaniodigital.gumroad.com)

**PERSONAL USE LICENSE**

This digital cookbook is licensed for personal, non-commercial use only.
You may print one (1) copy for your own kitchen use.

**YOU MAY NOT:**

- Share, resell, or redistribute this file in any form
- Upload to any website, cloud service, or file-sharing platform
- Remove or obscure any watermarks, copyright notices, or branding
- Use recipes for commercial food service without written permission

Violation of this license may result in legal action.

© 2024 DhanioDigital. All rights reserved.
Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

# Naan

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

COPYRIGHT

© 2026 Sweta Verma. All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced or distributed without written permission from the publisher.

DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

# A Persian Word, A Punjabi Icon

The word "naan" comes from the Persian word for bread, and leavened flatbreads baked against the walls of a clay oven have existed across Central and West Asia for well over a thousand years. In India, naan as we know it today took shape largely through Mughal court cuisine, as Persian-influenced culinary traditions blended with local Indian ingredients and techniques from the 16th century onward.

For most of its history in India, naan was not an everyday home bread — that role belonged to simple roti, cooked on a tava. Naan required a tandoor, the deep clay oven that could reach the intense, dry heat needed to puff and blister the dough in seconds, and tandoors were traditionally shared community ovens or the domain of restaurants and dhabas rather than home kitchens.

It was Punjab's roadside dhabas and Delhi's Mughlai restaurants that turned naan into the icon it is today, and from there it travelled with the Indian diaspora to become one of the most recognized Indian breads anywhere in the world. This recipe adapts the traditional tandoor method for a home stovetop or oven, so you can recreate that same soft, blistered bread without any special equipment.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

# A Persian Word, A Punjabi Icon, continued

### CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Traditionally a restaurant and special-occasion bread rather than a daily home staple, reserved for feasts, celebrations, and dining out. A centerpiece of North Indian and Mughlai cuisine, served alongside rich gravies like butter chicken and dal makhani. Naan varieties — plain, butter, garlic, stuffed — have become some of the most widely recognized Indian foods internationally, found on Indian restaurant menus worldwide.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

AT A GLANCE

# Equipment & preparation

| 20m | 1.5h | 20m | 6 |
|---|---|---|---|
| ACTIVE PREP | DOUGH RISE | COOK TIME | SERVINGS (6 NAANS) |

**Med**
DIFFICULTY

## Recommended equipment

- Large mixing bowl
- Rolling pin
- Heavy cast-iron tava, skillet, or a pizza stone/steel in the oven
- Basting brush for ghee or butter
- Tongs (helpful for the direct-flame finishing step)
- Tandoor — optional, for the fully traditional method

### STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Naan dough can be made a day ahead and refrigerated after its first rise — bring it back to room temperature before shaping. Cooked naan keeps at room temperature, wrapped in a clean towel, for a few hours, or refrigerated for 2 days. Reheat briefly on a hot tava or in a warm oven wrapped in foil; naan also freezes well for up to a month, layered with parchment paper.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

# Ingredients

## For the dough

| INGREDIENT | US | METRIC | INDIAN |
|---|---|---|---|
| All-purpose flour (maida) | 3 cups | 375 g | 3 katori |
| Instant yeast | 1 tsp | 3 g | 1 chammach |
| Sugar | 1 tsp | 4 g | 1 chammach |
| Plain yogurt | 3 tbsp | 45 g | 3 chammach |
| Milk, lukewarm | ½ cup | 120 ml | ½ katori |
| Water, lukewarm | ¼ cup | 60 ml | ¼ katori |
| Oil | 2 tbsp | 30 ml | 2 chammach |
| Salt | 1 tsp | 6 g | to taste |
| Ghee or melted butter (for basting) | 2 tbsp | 30 g | 2 chammach |
| Nigella seeds (kalonji) — optional | 1 tsp | 3 g | 1 chammach |

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

All-purpose flour gives the softest, most restaurant-style naan; substituting half with whole wheat flour makes a heartier, slightly denser version. If instant yeast isn't available, active dry yeast works the same way — just dissolve it in the warm milk with the sugar for 5–10 minutes until foamy before proceeding. Greek yogurt or any plain, unsweetened yogurt can stand in for regular dahi.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

# Making the Dough

## 01 ACTIVATE THE YEAST

Combine the warm milk, sugar, and yeast in a small bowl. Let it sit for 8–10 minutes until foamy — this confirms the yeast is active and will give the naan its rise.

## 02 MIX THE DOUGH

In a large bowl, combine the flour and salt. Add the yeast mixture, yogurt, oil, and warm water, mixing until a shaggy dough forms.

## 03 KNEAD UNTIL SMOOTH

Knead on a lightly floured surface for 8–10 minutes, until the dough is smooth, soft, and slightly tacky but not sticky.

**Chef tip.** a soft, well-hydrated dough is the secret to naan's pillowy texture — resist the urge to add too much extra flour while kneading.

## 04 LET IT RISE

Place the dough in a lightly oiled bowl, cover with a damp cloth, and let it rise in a warm spot for 1–1.5 hours, until roughly doubled in size.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

# Making the Dough, continued



**COOKING CHECKPOINT**

The dough is ready to shape when it has visibly doubled and holds an indent when gently pressed with a finger, springing back slowly.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

# Shaping & Cooking

## 05 DIVIDE AND SHAPE

Punch down the dough and divide into 6 equal balls. On a floured surface, roll or hand-stretch each ball into an oval or teardrop shape, about ¼ inch / 6 mm thick.

## 06 COOK ON A HOT TAVA

Heat a heavy tava or cast-iron skillet until very hot. Lightly wet one side of the rolled naan with water and press it, wet-side down, onto the hot pan — this helps it stick, mimicking how naan clings to a tandoor wall.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

# Shaping & Cooking, continued



## 07 FLIP AND CHAR

Cook until bubbles form and the underside is spotted golden-brown, 1–2 minutes. Flip and cook the other side, or for extra char, hold the naan directly over an open flame with tongs for a few seconds per side.

**Texture indicator.** naan is done when it puffs up with air pockets and shows deep brown blistered spots — pale naan means the pan wasn't hot enough.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

# Shaping & Cooking, continued

## 08 BASTE AND SERVE

Brush each naan generously with ghee or melted butter immediately off the heat, and sprinkle with nigella seeds if using. Stack and cover with a cloth to keep soft while you cook the rest.

**MISTAKE TO AVOID**

A pan that isn't hot enough is the most common reason naan turns out pale and tough instead of blistered and soft. Preheat your tava for a full 5 minutes over high heat before cooking the first naan.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

# How to serve



## Traditional Style

- Served hot and fresh straight off the tandoor, torn by hand to scoop up curries.
- A classic pairing with butter chicken, dal makhani, and paneer gravies.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

# How to serve, continued

## Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bread basket lined with cloth to retain warmth, brushed with visible ghee sheen.

## Family Style

- A shared stack at the center of the table alongside two or three curries for everyone to tear and share.

## Modern Pairing

- Works well as a wrap for grilled vegetables or paneer, or simply with a bowl of yogurt and pickle.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

# Chef secrets

## Getting the Softness Right

- Yogurt in the dough isn't just for tang — its acidity tenderizes the gluten for a softer bite.
- Don't over-knead once the dough is smooth; overworking naan dough can make it springy rather than tender.

## Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Dough can rise slowly overnight in the refrigerator for deeper flavor — bring to room temperature before shaping.
- Shaped, uncooked naan can be frozen between parchment sheets and cooked directly from frozen, adding a minute to the cook time.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Professional tandoor cooks often keep the dough slightly wetter than feels comfortable — a tacky dough steams internally in the intense heat, which is what creates naan's signature air pockets.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

# Nutrition, variations & FAQ

## APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

| 260 kcal | 7 g | 42 g | 7 g | 1.5 g |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| CALORIES | PROTEIN | CARBOHYDRATES | FAT | FIBER |

Estimates only; actual values vary with fat used and portion size.

### ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

## REGIONAL VARIATIONS

**Butter Naan** — finished with a generous double baste of butter — see our dedicated Butter Naan recipe card.

**Garlic Naan** — topped with minced garlic and coriander before cooking — see our dedicated Garlic Naan recipe card.

**Peshawari Naan** — stuffed with a sweet filling of chopped nuts, raisins, and desiccated coconut.

**Keema Naan** — stuffed with spiced minced meat, a popular Mughlai variation.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

# Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

## Can I make naan without a tandoor?

Yes — this recipe is specifically adapted for a stovetop cast-iron pan or an oven with a pizza stone/steel, both of which get close to authentic results.

## Can I make this without yeast?

Yes — a baking powder and baking soda version (sometimes called "quick naan") works, though the texture will be slightly less airy than a yeasted dough.

## Why did my naan turn out tough?

Usually over-kneading or a dough that's too dry. Keep the dough soft and slightly tacky, and knead just until smooth.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

# Ingredient glossary





© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

# Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

| | |
|---|---|
| **Tandoor** | a traditional clay oven capable of very high, dry heat. |
| **Kalonji** | nigella seeds, small black seeds with a mild oniony flavor, used as a naan topping. |
| **Maida** | refined white flour, the traditional base for naan dough. |
| **Dahi** | Hindi for yogurt, used both in the dough and as a marinade base in North Indian cooking. |



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

# Naan

| | |
|---|---|
| **20m** ACTIVE PREP | **1.5h** DOUGH RISE |
| **20m** COOK TIME | **6** SERVINGS (6 NAANS) |
| **Med** DIFFICULTY | |

## DOUGH

| | |
|---|---|
| All-purpose flour | 375 g |
| Instant yeast | 3 g |
| Sugar | 4 g |
| Plain yogurt | 45 g |
| Milk | 120 ml |
| Water | 60 ml |
| Oil | 30 ml |
| Salt | 6 g |
| Ghee or melted butter | 30 g |
| Nigella seeds | 3 g |

## METHOD

01 **Activate the yeast.** Combine the warm milk, sugar, and yeast in a small bowl.

02 **Mix the dough.** In a large bowl, combine the flour and salt.

03 **Knead until smooth.** Knead on a lightly floured surface for 8–10 minutes, until the dough is smooth, soft, and slightly tacky but not sticky.

04 **Let it rise.** Place the dough in a lightly oiled bowl, cover with a damp cloth, and let it rise in a warm spot for 1–1.5 hours, until roughly doubled in size.

05 **Divide and shape.** Punch down the dough and divide into 6 equal balls.

06 **Cook on a hot tava.** Heat a heavy tava or cast-iron skillet until very hot.

07 **Flip and char.** Cook until bubbles form and the underside is spotted golden-brown, 1–2 minutes.

08 **Baste and serve.** Brush each naan generously with ghee or melted butter immediately off the heat, and sprinkle with nigella seeds if using.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BEFORE YOU SHOP

# Shopping list

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ☐ | All-purpose flour | 375 g | |
| ☐ | Sugar | 4 g | |
| ☐ | Milk | 120 ml | |
| ☐ | Salt | 6 g | |
| ☐ | Nigella seeds | 3 g | |
| ☐ | Instant yeast | 3 g | |
| ☐ | Plain yogurt | 45 g | |
| ☐ | Oil | 30 ml | |
| ☐ | Ghee or melted butter | 30 g | |



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com